Using different languages inclusively during learning

Practical guide for students | D19-ST

Languages you know can help you develop ideas and understand subject content. Use them in ways that follow task requirements and allow everyone who needs to participate to understand the shared work.

1. Check the task requirements

Find out which stages allow a choice of language and which outputs must be in English. Check assessment rules for translation, AI and other assistance. Ask if requirements are unclear.

2. Use your languages purposefully

Where permitted, use a familiar language for private notes, initial ideas or checking a concept. Keep the English subject terms you will need for class, reading and assessment alongside your notes.

3. Agree on inclusive communication

In group work, discuss how everyone will follow the discussion and decisions. Do not assume classmates share a language because of their name, background or appearance.

4. Bring ideas into the shared discussion

Explain useful reasoning in a language everyone in the group can understand, as agreed for the task. Use a short summary, diagram or glossary to make the connection clear.

5. Check translations and meaning

A translated word may not carry the same disciplinary meaning. Compare it with course definitions and examples. Ask for clarification when a translation changes the concept or relationship.

6. Respect choices and participation

Do not pressure a classmate to disclose a language or act as an interpreter. If language choices exclude someone, pause and restate the important points so that everyone can contribute.

7. Example

You draft private notes in Vietnamese and English before discussing a business case. Your group agrees to discuss the recommendation in English so everyone can take part. You keep the key subject terms in English and check one uncertain translation against the course definition before sharing your reasoning.

8. Quick checklist

☐ I know the task's language and tool rules.

☐ My language choices support understanding.

☐ Everyone can follow the shared reasoning.

☐ I check important translations and respect choices.

9. When to seek further support

Ask your teacher if language requirements or permitted tools are unclear. If access to the shared discussion remains difficult, ask for support with the group process. Multilingual strategies can help learning, but persistent English-language needs may require additional provision.

10.Supporting sources

University of Minnesota, College of Continuing & Professional Studies. (n.d.). Fostering a Linguistically Inclusive and Asset-Based Classroom. Open resource

Educator guidance recognises multilingual resources and supports inclusive use of languages and communication. The student task-stage process is an adaptation.

University of Minnesota, College of Continuing & Professional Studies. (n.d.). Group Work/Projects. Open resource

Supports clarification, checking meaning and written contributions in group work; it does not establish rules for using particular languages.